

He and Susan married at age nineteen, and Gary attended a local college—a first for his family. Afterward, he took a teaching position and the couple started a family. Raising kids put a spotlight on his low teaching salary, though. It dawned on him that he couldn't even afford to save up for his children's college education, so he started looking for ways to boost his income. Ultimately, Gary decided to return to school and get a master's degree, which would increase his teacher's pay. "If you're going to be there teaching the same number of hours," he said, "you might as well get the most money you can per hour." Susan also added to the family income by going to school for an education degree and becoming a teacher herself. In all, Gary spent twenty years teaching, followed by another nine years in school administration. Then, after his retirement, he spent another five years teaching part time at a nearby college.

Throughout his and Susan's careers, the couple saved consistently month after month. They lived frugally and weren't afraid to make short-term sacrifices for long-term gains. Gary believes the main thing that keeps people from becoming millionaires is failing to understand what they could do with just a little bit of sacrifice. In fact, this couple didn't even buy their first home until they had saved up enough to pay cash, something that took a while on their teacher salaries. Over several decades, they took advantage of the available pensions and invested regularly into an IRA. They also set goals throughout their marriage to buy tracts of ranch land as an investment. Their first goal was to purchase 320 acres of grass. When they hit that goal, they set a new one. When they hit the new goal, they did it again. And again. And again. Today, Gary and Susan own 5,400 acres of land in Iowa, which they rent out to farmers. That not only provides a steady stream of passive rental income but also, along with their other investments, contributes to their incredible \$10 million net worth today. Gary set those goals based on these wise words from his father: "You'll never get ahead unless you find a way to make money while you're sleeping."

Making money while you're asleep is one of the key strategies millionaires use to build wealth, but that only happens when you make a plan and work toward it consistently over time. So let's dig in to better understand how these men and women wake up wealthier than they were when they went to bed. It starts by understanding compound interest.